



Figure 1: The Parallels Workstation Installation Wizard (Registration Process)



Figure 2: Customising Qemu (Enabling Full Acceleration)

likes of BSD, Solaris and even DOS or Windows 3.x. Like Qemu, VirtualBox is also open source software.

VMware Player

VMware Player is a commercial virtualisation product that lets you run multiple operating systems on your computer. The product is free (as in *free beer*) for personal use, and paid enterprise versions are available, but sadly, none of the offerings are open source. Beyond that, VMware Player offers excellent support for multiple operating systems, and binary downloads are available for both RHEL and Ubuntu users (32-bit and 64-bit).

Parallels Workstation

Parallels Workstation is paid-for, commercial, closed source



Figure 3: VirtualBox running Ubuntu as the guest OS

virtualisation software available for Windows, Mac and Linux. A cheaper, non-enterprise version by the name of Parallels Desktop is also available. If you are compelled to compromise with closed source software, it is likely that you have a good 'business' reason behind it, and so we will review Parallels Workstation in this article.

With that general introduction out of the way, let us now compare each option's performance under separate heads.

Installation

Beginning with Qemu, the installation process is pretty simple. In fact, Qemu is nowadays offered in the repositories of almost every major distro and so, installation is just a matter of a few clicks. Also, Kernel Virtualization Machine (KVM), which is supported by Qemu, is nowadays a part of the standard installation of most notable distros, including Ubuntu.

Similarly, VirtualBox, too, forms a part of the repositories of many distros. However, just in case your distro does not offer VirtualBox, you can always download the binaries from <https://www.virtualbox.org/wiki/Downloads>

The installation of Parallels Workstation, on the other hand, is outright complex. You can either add custom repositories for third party software in your distro's software manager, or you can download it from the Parallels' website itself. If you are downloading it from the website, you'll need to register for a user account (yes, that's how it is with closed source software—you have to register). And speaking of registration, you will be required to give a plethora of information about yourself—your name, work information, address, and so on.

Thereafter, the URL to the download location will be sent to you via e-mail. Since the software is paid for, you'll have a 30-day trial period during which you can use the software without paying the licence fee, following which, you have to either purchase a license key or remove the software. During the installation process, you will also be presented with the End User License Agreement (EULA) which you need to agree to conform to, before carrying on with the installation.

Speaking of VMware Player, the installation is more or less similar to that of Parallels Workstation – you have to register for an account on the website (though in this case, you're required to give only your name and e-mail address),